Philosophy of Religion

Religionsfilosofi

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Alte dubitat, qui altius credit.

(He doubts more deeply who believes more deeply.)

Contents

1 Problem and Procedure **5**

2 Epistemological Philosophy of Religion **15**

2.1 Understanding 15

2.1.1 Causal Explanation 15

2.1.2 The World of Space 15

2.1.3 The Course of Time 15

2.2 Concluding Thoughts 15

2.3 Thought and Image 15

3 Psychological Philosophy of Religion **17**

3.1 Religious Experience and Religious Faith 18

3.1.1 Religious Experience 18

3.1.2 Religious Faith 18

3.2 The Development of Religious Ideas 18

3.2.1 Religion as Drive 18

3.2.2 Polytheism and Monotheism 18

3.2.3 Religious Experience and Tradition 18

3.2.4 The Scientific Conclusion of the Psychology of Religion . . . 18

3.3 Dogmas and Symbols 18

3.4 The Proposition of the Persistence of Value 18

3.4.1 More Precise Determination of the Proposition of the Persistence of Value and of its Relation to Experience 18

3.4.2 Psychological-Historical Discussion of the Proposition of the Persistence of Value 18

3.4.3 General Philosophical Discussion of the Proposition of the Persistence of Value 18

3.5 The Principle of Personality 18

3.5.1 The Significance and Justification of the Principle of Personality 18
3.5.2 Main Groups of Personal Differences 18
3.5.3 Buddha and Jesus 18
3.5.4 Is the Principle of Personality a Principle of Growth or of Dissolution? 18
3.5.5 Layman and Scholar 18

4 Ethical Philosophy of Religion 19
4.1 Religion as the Foundation of Ethics 19
4.2 Religion as a Form of Spiritual Culture 19
4.2.1 Psychological Considerations 19
4.2.2 Sociological Considerations 19
4.3 Primitive Christianity and Modern Christianity 19
4.4 We Live on Realities 19

Notes 21

Chapter 1

Problem and Procedure

ou lyseis agnoōn ton desmon.
ARISTOTLE.
(One cannot untie a knot without knowing where it is bound).

1. By *philosophy of religion* one could mean either a thinking that springs from religion and builds on religion, or a thinking that takes religion as its object. It is in this latter sense that the term shall be taken here. The thinking that springs from and builds on religion itself belongs to the subject matter of the philosophy of religion and should not be called philosophy of religion.

By religion we think first of all of a state of mind in which feeling and need, fear and hope, enthusiasm and devotion play a larger role than reflection and inquiry, and in which intuition and image hold more sway than investigation and reasoning. To be sure, again and again in the religious life there will arise an involuntary need to give an account of one's condition and of its content—of the worth of one's motives and the validity of one's thoughts. But the religious thinking that thus arises does not pose the religious problem in a decisive way. Its problems arise within religion, but religion itself does not become a problem. No other starting point is yet recognized than religion itself; in any case other starting points are so subordinate in relation to religion that they do not acquire decisive significance. Of this kind is religious thinking in those times in which religion is everything on the spiritual plane. These are the classical times of religion: partly the great times of origins, in which religion with all the power of originality draws all strength and interest to itself; partly the great times of organization, in which all existing culture is shaped or bent into obedience under the highest religious ideas. In such classical times there is a

great unity, or at least a great harmony, in the domain of spiritual life. Christianity had such a classical time in the age of the primitive Christian community, and later in the great organizational period at the height of the Middle Ages. A religious problem forms only when other sides of spiritual life—science and art, morality and social life—begin to free themselves and to appear with the claim of having independent value. They then judge religion from their points of view and by their standards, whereas religion in its classical times either simply ignored them—as in the times of origins—or—as in the times of organization—valued them from its own point of view and by its own standard, so that the question became whether these two different evaluations could be brought into mutual harmony.—There must be definite historical conditions present before the religious problem can be posed in a decisive way. It is, if one will, only in unhappy times that a religious problem exists. For this problem is the expression of a spiritual disharmony: the different elements of spiritual life no longer work together in so unified a way as before; they lead in different directions, among which one must perhaps ultimately choose. But then both the necessity and the possibility of an investigation are also present.

That religion is made into a problem will be offensive to many. But thought must have the right to investigate everything, once it has awakened, and only thought itself can mark out its boundaries. Who else should mark out its boundaries? He who perceives no problem has of course no reason to think; but neither has he any reason to prevent others from thinking. He who fears losing his spiritual support must keep away. No one wishes to rob the poor man of his only lamb—but then the poor man must not unnecessarily come dragging it along the highway and demand that traffic be stopped on his account. Experience shows, moreover, that it is rather the oxen than the lambs that loudly announce themselves with their indignation in season and out of season (especially out of season). It is not so much the genuinely poor in spirit as the stiff and blustering dogmatists who take offense when free inquiry claims the right to stir on the religious plane as on any other.

The investigation I wish to undertake here addresses itself neither to those who are finished nor to those who are fearful. The finished are found in every camp, not least among the so-called "freethinkers"—a class of people who, like the "Worms" in Linnaeus's system, can be characterized only by negative predicates, because the class is supposed to encompass so many different forms. The finished are in possession of a definite negative or positive solution to the religious problem and have thereby lost the sense for further thinking about it. The fearful dare not think

about it.—Rather, the investigation addresses itself to those who are *becoming*. "One who is becoming will always be grateful"—no matter in which direction his becoming goes.

Philosophy is, as is well known, richer in ideas, perspectives, and discussions than in definitive results, and the philosopher would often be in a sorry state if he did not believe that the constant striving after truth belongs to the highest spiritual values, which it is the task of all true religion to uphold. Even if we could learn nothing else from a philosophy-of-religion investigation, we could perhaps learn something about the causes of the strife that rages over religious questions, and about this strife's significance for the development of spiritual life. And should the religious problem prove insoluble, we might perhaps learn why it is insoluble.

2. The philosophy of religion should not proceed from a finished philosophical system. In a certain sense all thinking must be systematic, for "system" literally means "that which stands together," and it is an inexorable demand placed on our thoughts that they must be able to "stand together" with one another. There is an inner coherence and consistency which in every domain is the ultimate mark of truth, and which must therefore also be required in the domain of the philosophy of religion. But the philosophy-of-religion enterprise will be most fruitful where religion and its phenomena are not placed in relation to an already completed philosophical conception, but are illuminated by a philosophizing that is itself in the process of investigating whether a completion is possible at all. The task is to discuss religion's relation to spiritual life. Religion is itself a kind of or form of spiritual life, and it is judged rightly only when seen in its relation to other kinds or forms. It is no alien standard that is thereby applied to religion. For there is a service from which no spiritual power—even if it appears under the greatest names—can exempt itself, namely to serve the deep and rich development of spiritual life. The philosophy-of-religion task will therefore above all be to find the means for investigating whether religion, under the conditions of our spiritual culture, can continue to render such service. In solving, or better: in treating this task, the philosophy of religion cannot come equipped with other presuppositions than those which every other science brings to the treatment of its subject. Very often it will surely be compelled to declare that there are questions that cannot be answered, because the conditions in the spiritual domain are more complex and more diverse than positive and negative dogmatists suppose. Yet it is not without significance that the problems are discussed. The conscious insight into the impossibility of a solution

(*docta ignorantia*) naturally invites one to investigate whether it is then so absolutely necessary that a solution be found. In addition, one's eye will be sharpened for the particular conditions under which our spiritual culture lives, conditions which would probably not continue to persist, just as they even now do not exert equal influence on all personalities.

A philosophy-of-religion investigation can suitably be arranged so as to consist of an epistemological, a psychological, and an ethical part.

In its classical times, religion satisfies all of humankind's spiritual needs, including its drive for knowledge. Religious ideas then contain for human beings the explanation of existence in its entirety and in its individual parts. But when an independent science has developed, another kind of understanding or explanation appears alongside the religious one, and the question becomes whether these two kinds are compatible. Possibly the situation might be that the new, scientific mode of explanation increasingly replaces the religious explanation where particulars are concerned, but that it cannot be applied to existence considered as a whole—to what one customarily calls the "first" or the "last" questions. Then one must discuss whether religion is able to solve the riddles that science cannot solve. If it should then turn out that religious conceptions, whether with respect to the whole or to the particular, cannot help with anything that could rightly be called understanding or explanation, then one must raise the question what significance these conceptions can still have.

This last question leads from the epistemological philosophy of religion to the psychological. For if religious conceptions no longer have cognitive value, the value they might possess must consist in being expressions of sides of the life of the soul other than the intellectual. An attempt must then be made to describe the religious life of the soul, especially the relation of conceptions to religious experience and religious feeling. Through this it will become apparent that religion in its innermost nature has to do not with the understanding of existence but with the *evaluation* of it, and that religious conceptions express the relation in which factual existence, as we know it, stands to that which for us gives life its highest value. The core of religion is—according to the hypothesis to which we are led—a faith in the persistence of value in existence. This faith appears in great, vivid images in the popular religions, especially in the highest among them. Even in those who stand outside every popular religion, such a faith may stir, even though it does not here take definite shape.

The transition from psychological to ethical philosophy of religion is naturally motivated by the question: what ethical value does it have that one believes in the persistence of value? Ethics concerns the production of values, and the possibility cannot be dismissed that the work of producing values leaves no time and no strength for living in the thought of their persistence. The ethical philosophy of religion forms a parallel to the epistemological. In its classical times, religion directly and indirectly determines the evaluation of all actions and all conditions of life. The religious problem arises on this point when an independent ethics has developed that seeks, by its own path, the grounding and motivation for the evaluation of human actions. And on this point the problem is posed in the sharpest and most pressing way, for the ultimate standard for judging religion must belong to the ethical domain, where the final reckoning of the spiritual account takes place.—

Within the framework here indicated, we should be able to find room for all essential aspects of the religious problem. I wish to treat this problem not only with the intellectual interest that is aroused by a great and comprehensive subject, but also in the mood that comes from the consciousness of standing before a spiritual form of life in which the human race through millennia has deposited some of its deepest and most inward experiences.

3. Before we enter upon the individual parts of the philosophy of religion, it will be useful to give a somewhat more detailed characterization of the content of the religious problem.

In the Protestant world it is fairly generally acknowledged that one must distinguish between knowledge and faith. The Catholic Church does not acknowledge this distinction in its full extent and therefore does not acknowledge any religious problem in the intellectual domain. It maintains that God's existence can be proved by the paths that Thomas Aquinas, supported by Aristotle, pointed out, and it has even declared it a matter of faith to accept that these proofs suffice. The tradition from the great time of the Middle Ages, when "one did not doubt and was therefore nearer to the truth" (to use a sentence from one of Thomas Aquinas's modern biographers), is continually upheld, and it is not acknowledged that a disharmony has really entered into spiritual life. The distinction between knowledge and faith concedes that such a disharmony is present—that the unity of spiritual life is broken. Is this distinction itself then only a station on the way, in that development will lead to an elimination of all religion from spiritual life, because only that can endure which can enter into a harmonious relation with the other elements of life?—Whether one now

assumes that it is only the classical time of religion that is past, or that its time is altogether past, the question cannot be set aside whether spiritual value is lost in the process of dissolution that has set in, or whether a replacement can be found for the spiritual unity and self-containment that was lost. This consideration alone shows that the question of the persistence of value is an essential aspect of the religious problem, whatever solution one inclines toward. It is not least from this side that philosophy in the last century and a half (from the time of Rousseau, Lessing, and Kant onward) has treated the religious problem. Both Romantics and Positivists have been attentive to this aspect of it.—It must of course be remembered that even if one could show that no spiritual energy was lost in the dissolution of religion, it does not follow that the energy would under the new conditions receive as valuable an application as in the classical times of religion. In the spiritual domain no less than in the material, the conservation of energy is not without further ado the same as the persistence of value. Energy can persist without value persisting, while the reverse cannot well be imagined, since energy in and of itself will be a condition for the persistence and development of what is valuable. Many freethinkers proceed without further ado from the assumption that human life will become more powerful and richer when religion falls away—an assumption that is not self-evident and that rests on the presupposition that psychic equivalents are present—equivalents both in terms of value and in terms of energy. The task will then be to demonstrate these equivalents and thereby establish the persistence of value. But it is a great question and an essential aspect of the religious problem whether such equivalents can be demonstrated.—Moreover, the problem of the persistence of value will also arise within the Church, for religion and the religious life undergo constant changes; and the question becomes whether the values from the classical times of religion persist through these changes—e.g., whether primitive Christianity, both in terms of value and in terms of energy, is preserved in the Christianity of our day. In its sharpest form this problem has appeared in the assertion: "the Christianity of the New Testament no longer exists."—

But the religious problem concerns not only the persistence of value within the human world. It raises not only a psychological but also a cosmological question, namely about the relation between that which stands as the highest value for human beings and the whole of existence. Is there any connection between values and the laws and forces of existence? Are these laws and forces perhaps even ultimately determined by the highest values? Or can we perhaps not ascribe any validity to

the concept of value beyond the domain of human life?

The hypothesis that will later (in the psychological philosophy of religion) be sought to be grounded holds that the proposition of the persistence of value is the actual religious axiom, which is expressed in different ways in the different religions and at the different religious standpoints. The religious problem thus concerns the question whether this axiom can really be taken to hold. And at the same time this axiom, insofar as it expresses the fundamental thought of all religion, can be used as a standard for the consistency and significance of the individual religion or the individual religious standpoint. Finally—as already noted—the relation between ethics and religion can, with the help of this axiom, be expressed in a very simple way: how does faith in the persistence of value relate to the work of finding, producing, and preserving values?—

If the proposition of the persistence of value were to be discussed in its full scope, the discussion would become interminable, and clear starting points for conducting it would soon be lacking. I therefore emphasize at once the limits within which my investigation will move, and which must be kept in mind throughout all that follows.—When I attempt to show that the said proposition is the fundamental thought of all religion, this attempt will not have failed because it turns out that no religion expresses the proposition with clarity and consistency. It will be sufficient if an explicit need or tendency to hold fast to this fundamental thought can be demonstrated, so that the standard for the evaluation of religions in their mutual relations becomes the degree to which they are able to articulate and carry through the proposition.—When the persistence of value is spoken of, this could be understood to mean that value does not vanish, but that there is constantly value in existence, whether it decreases or increases or alternates between decrease and increase. But I understand the expression *the persistence of value* in analogy with the expression *the conservation of energy*, such that the proposition asserts a constant persistence of value through all changes of form. It will perhaps be necessary here to distinguish between potential and actual value, just as one distinguishes between potential and actual energy, and the one distinction is just as clear and just as justified as the other.—But the persistence of value through all changes of form and despite the difference between possibility and actuality is nonetheless only a minimum. It may be maintained that the mere persistence of value is not satisfying and actually contains a contradiction, since value can persist only by growing, since mere repetition dulls, while on the other hand change is valuable only when it brings enhancement. That

an increase of value does not conflict with the conservation of energy needs no further demonstration; the increase of value presupposes only a new and more perfect application of energy, not an increase of energy as a whole. It is for the sake of simplicity that I limit the investigation to the persistence of value. And it will also turn out that religious consciousness has at bottom limited itself to this as well. The persistence of value will present us with difficulties and tasks enough, even if we do not enter into everything that lies in the unavoidable consequence that value can persist only if it increases. Yet we must not forget that this consequence is present.—Finally, when the persistence of value is under discussion, one might ask: which value and how much value? I enter into these questions only insofar as the difference between the different religions and religious standpoints essentially depends on the different answers they give to them. It is clear that the proposition of the persistence of value can be accepted whatever answers one gives. The hypothesis that the persistence of value is the fundamental religious proposition is not shaken by the fact that the different religions and religious standpoints diverge greatly from one another with respect to the character and extent of the valuable in whose persistence they believe.

Value is the property of something that it brings about a real satisfaction or can become the means to such. Value can therefore be immediate or mediate. Immediate value we seek to hold fast when it is given, and to produce when it is not given. We thus make it our end. That we make something an end presupposes, conversely, that we have an experience or a supposition of its immediate value. Mediate value belongs to that which serves the attainment of an end—that is, of an immediate value. Mediate value need not be potential value. For what serves as a means for attaining something of immediate value itself acquires value in our eyes, even though its value stands as derived. There are all possible transitions between mediate and immediate value, and through the shifting of motives the former passes over into the latter, so that what at first had value only as a means now acquires value as an end. Potential value, on the other hand, often means only the possibility that something will acquire value as a means—that is, the possibility of mediate value.—Which values are experienced and therefore acknowledged at the different standpoints will depend on the different character of those standpoints. It is a being's nature that determines its need, and it is its need that determines what acquires value for it. The religious axiom thus shows the necessity of a religion's character being determined by the nature and need of the human beings who profess it. For one cannot seriously

believe in the persistence of values that one does not know at least approximately from one's own experience.—

It is to Kant's philosophy that we owe the independence of the problem of value from the problem of knowledge. He taught us to distinguish between evaluation and explanation. That this distinction cannot, however, be a complete opposition is clear from the fact that it must depend on the laws and forces of existence whether something can acquire value for us and whether we can make the valuable into an end that can be realized. The religious problem can therefore not be separated from the other philosophical problems, even though it is most advantageous to treat it by itself. It presents a clear analogy with the other problems. The fundamental philosophical problem concerns the continuity of existence in its relation to the special and individual forms of existence. And if the hypothesis that the proposition of the persistence of value is the religious axiom turns out to be well-founded, then the religious problem concerns the continuity of existence from a distinctive point of view and thus falls under the fundamental problem as a special form of it.

Chapter 2

Epistemological Philosophy of Religion

2.1 Understanding

Ihm ziemt's die Welt im Innern zu bewegen.

GOETHE.

(It befits him to move the world from within.)

4. Against the supposition I have put forward, that the core of religion is faith in the persistence of value, it might seem to tell that theoretical motives have after all played, and still for many play, a considerable role in the development of religious ideas. I have moreover already remarked that since religion in its classical times is everything for the human being, it in such times also satisfies its drive for knowledge—that is, provides it with means for and forms of understanding and explanation of existence. In the classical times of religion there exists no independent drive for knowledge, any more than special means and forms for satisfying such a drive. The distinction between knowledge and faith, between understanding and evaluation, first emerges in the critical times—that is, in the times when religion has become a problem. This distinction has only begun to gain acceptance after several violent collisions between religion and science. Only reluctantly has the religious side begun to learn that it is not the business of religion to give us a scientific understanding of the world. What all theologians now repeat, that the Bible is not meant to teach us natural science, no one wished to hear when Bruno, Galilei, and Spinoza said it. The persecution of heretics ran its course, and only afterwards did

one see the correctness of what the heretics had said. In other domains the same strife repeats itself; in our day it is the independence of the human sciences that is at stake.

Every great religion appears in history with a worldview, in that it in a distinctive way gathers into itself the entire circle of ideas of its time. Christianity, for example, stood in the first centuries also by its intellectual content as attractive to many. Tatian thus converted to Christianity because this "philosophy of the barbarians," as he called it, seemed to him to explain what he had not previously understood: "the origin of the world." The ancient apologists stood altogether on the position that Christianity contained the best solution to the riddles of thought. When Plato and other Greek philosophers seemed to suggest similar solutions, this was according to Justin Martyr to be explained either by their having been influenced by the Israelite prophets, or else by the "Word" (Logos) having, before it became flesh, worked illuminatingly in the inner life of human beings. In comparison with earlier religions, Christianity had—as is generally the case with higher religions in relation to lower ones—a certain rational character and above all a simplicity, a plain grandeur, that must have been attractive to many who knew only the earlier religions with their colorful mythologies. Insofar as the worldview given in the biblical scriptures was not detailed enough, the Church Fathers and Scholastics supplemented it with the help of Greek science.

Just as Christianity stands for the Western world, so does Buddhism stand for the Eastern world not merely as a great religion but as a great worldview whose ideas have a certain rational character and cannot be understood without knowledge of the preceding Indian thought.

When the opposition between religious and scientific understanding of existence is discussed, the emphasis is usually placed on the fact that science—especially in the domains of astronomy, geology, and biology—has led to results that conflict with the received teachings of religion. A large part of the work of modern apologists accordingly aims at showing the compatibility of the received religious ideas with the scientific results that really stand fast. One applies to modern natural science, with greater or lesser success—and with greater or lesser taste—the same process of accommodation that the apologists of antiquity applied to Greek science. But for illuminating the religious problem in its entirety, this whole discussion for and against is of little interest, except perhaps insofar as it provides characteristic examples of the accommodation that religious imaginative life—like everything living—undergoes

or strives to undergo in the face of new conditions of life.

What is rather the main point is that it is two entirely different kinds or types of "understanding" that here stand opposed to each other. They are two ways of thinking and of explaining events—two ways so different that once one has begun with the one, one will not be able to find any point at which it is justified and possible to cross over to the other. The entire spiritual condition is so different in kind that the word "understanding" is in reality used here in two entirely different senses. Let me take a single example. A sudden storm and flood tide, which causes the destruction of many fishermen at sea, is explained scientifically by the states of the air and sea in the preceding days. But in the funeral oration over the victims, the "understanding" of what has happened is found in the claim that God wished to give the survivors a sign, so that they should repent. At which point in the series of natural causes can one imagine that this divine intervention took place? The natural causes form a connected series in which no link can be removed. One must choose between the two "understandings." The one kind of understanding aims at forming, as far as possible, connected series of links, each of which can be demonstrated in experience. The more the states of air and sea at the moment of the catastrophe are brought into connected sequence with their states in the preceding days, the better one says—according to the one type of understanding—that one understands the catastrophe. According to the other type, the catastrophe is understood through the value it acquires by virtue of its influence on the minds of those who suffer under it, and this value is regarded as intended—as the purpose of a divine intervention.

The scientific type of understanding has developed in a particularly clear and fruitful way in the course of the last three centuries. It does not exclude a religious evaluation, but it excludes a confusion of this evaluation with actual explanation. It is the task of philosophical epistemology to investigate the presuppositions and the forms of thought that underlie scientific knowledge, and it will be of philosophy-of-religion interest to bring out these presuppositions and forms of thought and compare them with the basis of religious "understanding." Through this we shall be able to gain illumination as to whether religion can continue to have significance for the satisfaction of our drive for knowledge.

2.1.1 Causal Explanation

5. To understand is to lead something hitherto unknown back to something known. To understand something is not always the same as demonstrating its cause; one

can understand what something is without understanding why it is what it is or why it exists at all. And the very understanding of why something is as it is can be of different kinds.

Understanding can mean recognition (perception). I understand a language when I know the sounds, so that I can connect the right meaning with them. I understand what the white thing between the bushes is when I realize that it is a strip of mist on which the moon is shining. I understand a proposition when the connection between subject and predicate that the speaker or writer has wished to assert is recognized by me.—In these examples, understanding rests on the discovery of identity.

For the understanding of a proposition, however, something more may be required. Because I understand what the meaning of a particular proposition is, I do not thereby understand why the proposition was put forward. This latter understanding comes only when I can derive the proposition from other propositions, until I arrive at propositions that already stand firm for me. Understanding here means grounding. The proposition "A is C" I do not understand (in this sense of the word) until I see that it follows from "A is B" and "B is C."—Here understanding rests on rationality.

An event in the mental or the material world I understand (in the first sense) when I know what has happened. And I understand it (in the second sense) when I know why I assume that it has happened. But there is yet a third kind of understanding possible. To understand an event can mean to derive it from earlier events, so that from the occurrence of the latter one can infer the occurrence of the former. Here understanding means causal explanation and consists in the discovery of causality.

Identity, rationality, and causality are related.—Rationality, the relation between ground (premises) and consequent (conclusion), presupposes identity. The proposition "A is C" is in a sense already contained in the two propositions "A is B" and "B is C," and is really only another expression for the content of these two propositions—an expression that arises when I substitute for B in the first proposition B's predicate (C) in the second proposition, which I must do when the two B's are really identical. The conclusion arises from a combination of the premises.—Causality in turn presupposes rationality. The relation between cause and effect is analogous to that between ground and consequent. Two events stand in a causal relation to each other when they not only follow one another in time, but when the one that occurs first also stands to the other as ground to consequent. Causality contains rationality but presupposes in addition that a change has occurred, a transition in time from one event to another. The effect lies in a certain

sense in the cause, but is nonetheless more than a purely logical conversion of the cause into another form. In the transition from cause to effect, it is not merely our thought that passes from one form to another, but a process of transition takes place in reality itself. The great question is whether all relations between real events are causal relations.

When one posits the proposition that every event has its cause—the so-called causal principle—one thereby establishes the principle that existence is intelligible in the third sense of the word. This proposition can never become more than a hypothesis, since we can never understand everything, demonstrate causes for all events. But it contains the presupposition with which we involuntarily meet events that arouse our attention; in any case it is the presupposition that brings us to look around for earlier events when an event has occurred.

We can here entirely disregard the question of the causal principle's grounding and origin, since the mutually divergent views that could be given here need not acquire significance for the philosophy of religion. Whether the acknowledgment of this principle is due to habit or to an inner necessity in our nature, the need to find causes stirs more or less in everyone, and the religious conception bears witness to this no less than the scientific. Indeed, religious ideas have a particular epistemological interest precisely in that they testify to how deeply the need to find causes lies in human nature, manifesting itself even where no independent scientific interest has yet arisen. The opposition between religion and science first emerges when attention is paid to the character of the causes one acknowledges as correct, real causes (*verae causae*). Both religious and scientific understanding is a leading-back of the unknown to the known; the difference between them depends on what this known is.

Scientific understanding requires that the cause of an event be demonstrated in events that themselves establish themselves in experience just as well as the event to be explained. The task here becomes to interpret the series of events by finding as many individual links in this series, and as close a connection between them, as possible. The aim is to interpret nature by nature itself, just as one interprets a passage in a book by comparing it with other passages in the same book. Religious understanding does not make the demand that the cause should stand in continuous connection with the effect and itself be demonstrated as an experience just as well as the event to be explained. It does not investigate its causes in the critical manner that science does. It does not explain nature by nature itself,

but by something that is different from or stands outside nature, that "pushes in from without." Thus, at any rate, religious understanding most frequently appears in history; whether it is necessary that it appear in this form, and therefore in marked opposition to scientific understanding, will be shown later. In contrast to this religious understanding, the special form that empirical science—in both the mental and the material domains—gives to the causal principle can be designated as the principle of natural causes. If it cannot be applied, we understand nothing, when it is the scientific type of understanding and the corresponding intellectual habitus that prevails in us.

6. But on what, then, is the principle of natural causes grounded?—A whole series of reasons can be adduced for the fact that this principle has worked its way forward and more and more determines the way in which the human consciousness confronts events when it is a matter of understanding them.

It is not enough to devise a causal explanation. It must also be shown that this explanation is confirmed by experience. Such a confirmation (verification) is achieved when we see that upon the recurrence of the same conditions, the same event occurs as last time. But it is clear that such a confirmation is possible only when the cause is itself an event that can appear in indubitable experience. If, for example, the explanation of the storm and flood tide discussed above (§4) is correct, then these events must recur when the same conditions in air and sea are present, and this must be capable of being established. To derive events from divine intentions is, on the other hand, no scientific explanation; for whether such intentions are present in the individual case cannot be established, and the explanation therefore cannot be tested. It was precisely for this reason, not from hostility to religion, that Galilei, Bacon, and Descartes declared the so-called final causes to be unscientific.

But in addition, only the principle of natural causes satisfies the need for a specific explanation of the individual, determinate event. Galilei showed, for instance, that in the debate between the various contending astronomical hypotheses it was of no use to appeal to God's intervention, since for God's omnipotence it is just as easy to make the sun move around the earth as to make the earth move around the sun. This cause therefore cannot help us to a choice between the hypotheses. It is a key that opens everywhere; but it is not such a master key that science seeks; science's interest is to investigate the particular character of the different locks, and it therefore demands a special key for every lock. If a master key were sufficient, the difference between the locks would become meaningless—and would contain an

unsolved problem!—To appeal to God's will gives no scientific understanding, but is—scientifically considered—an admission that one does not understand the event.

Furthermore. In doubtful cases we have only one criterion by which we can distinguish between imagination and reality, namely the firm, unshakeable connection between the individual phenomenon and the rest of our experience. The more detached the individual phenomenon stands in relation to the rest of our experience—the greater the leaps between the links in the series of events—the more heterogeneous the links are—the less certainty we have that we stand before a reality. In doubtful cases we therefore continue to search for intermediate links in experience until we have found a continuous and unshakeable connection. It is clear that the application of this criterion of reality is one and the same thing as the application of the principle of natural causes.

The deepest grounding for the principle of natural causes I find in a need for continuity that lies in the nature of our consciousness, and that already manifests itself in the general need to find causes. Our consciousness involuntarily strives to gather and connect its elements and to preserve its unity with itself, even when it confronts new content. It then strives to shape, modify, and adjust the new content so that the new turns out to be a new form of something old. Self-recognition then becomes possible despite the changing of content, and the unity of personal life is reflected in the continuity that is thereby brought about. The work of knowledge is here closely connected with the work of developing character. Of a character we speak—in the emphatic sense—only where unity and continuity prevail in the whole striving and one does not again and again leap over to something new. In analogy with this, knowledge seeks to find as much unity and continuity as possible, to show the new as a conversion or continuation of the old; and only where this succeeds is a full appropriation and understanding won. The principle of natural causes, which leads to the building of series as long and as continuous as possible, is therefore no accident but is closely connected with the very nature of personality. It is therefore wrong when personality and science are set in sharp opposition to each other. Scientific work is personality-work. And the more this work succeeds, the more causal explanation approaches grounding and recognition. The differences in existence are reduced to the smallest possible measure when with a single glance, "under the aspect of eternity," we survey great regions of existence.

2.1.2 The World of Space

2.1.3 The Course of Time

2.2 Concluding Thoughts

2.3 Thought and Image

Chapter 3

Psychological Philosophy of Religion

3.1 Religious Experience and Religious Faith

3.1.1 Religious Experience

3.1.2 Religious Faith

3.2 The Development of Religious Ideas

3.2.1 Religion as Drive

3.2.2 Polytheism and Monotheism

3.2.3 Religious Experience and Tradition

3.2.4 The Scientific Conclusion of the Psychology of Religion

3.3 Dogmas and Symbols

3.4 The Proposition of the Persistence of Value

3.4.1 More Precise Determination of the Proposition of the Persistence of Value and of its Relation to Experience

3.4.2 Psychological-Historical Discussion of the Proposition of the Persistence of Value

3.4.3 General Philosophical Discussion of the Proposition of the Persistence of Value

3.5 The Principle of Personality

Chapter 4

Ethical Philosophy of Religion

4.1 Religion as the Foundation of Ethics

4.2 Religion as a Form of Spiritual Culture

4.2.1 Psychological Considerations

4.2.2 Sociological Considerations

4.3 Primitive Christianity and Modern Christianity

4.4 We Live on Realities

Notes